

PAPERBOY

A Novel



Joselito “Jojo” Sering

PAPERBOY

by Joselito “Jojo” Sering

Copyright © 2026 Joselito Sering. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or by any information storage and retrieval system, without permission in writing from the publisher.

This book is based on memoirs written as an assignment for English class at El Camino High School in 1986 and developed into a novella over the course of forty years.

This is a work of fiction based on the author’s memoir. Names, characters, places, and incidents are products of the author’s imagination or are used fictitiously.

Content warning: this book contains depictions of child abuse, racial violence, and explicit language.

First Edition, 2026

Printed in the United States of America

For Mama, who believed in three things.

Every immigrant is a sentence that began in one language and ended in another. The grammar is survival. The punctuation is a hyphen that never stops traveling.

Contents

1. Fresh Off The Sushi Boat
2. Welcome to America
3. Jesus Saves
4. Magazine
5. Batter, Batter, Swing
6. Blue Derby
7. Chinaman
8. Dogeaters
9. L-e-p-r-e-c-h-a-u-n
10. Rocker Chicks Rule
11. 11
12. No Remorse
13. Foggy Memory

CHAPTER 1

Fresh Off The Sushi Boat

*Mama called it an upgrade. She said the word the way she said grace
— fast, certain, and only once.*

Mama called it an upgrade. She'd written it in the letters, the ones that came in thin blue airmail envelopes with American stamps and her convent handwriting, every loop identical, like she'd practiced being legible her whole life because someone had once told her illegible girls didn't get hired. Upgrade. Jojo turned the word over the way he turned over the coins Kuya Bert let him keep from the ashtray in the car. It sounded like a toy you got for behaving. It sounded like something with a bag and a receipt.

He was nine. His birthday was September 30, 1971, which on March 3, 1981, made him nine exactly, no fractions, no almost. Still short enough that the airplane seatbelt cut across his stomach instead of his hips. Still the kind of nine-year-old who believed the things his mother put in writing, because his mother did not write things that weren't true, she only left things out, which — he would spend the rest of his life discovering — is a different skill entirely, and a more useful one.

What he was leaving: a house with three maids; a cook, a cleaner, and a nanny. A driver named Kuya Bert — “kuya” is a title reserved for all the men who did not yet earn the respects of a Tito — who let him sit up front and hold the wheel at forty kilometers an hour, both of them laughing like it was a heist. A yard with a chicken in it, whom he had named nothing, because you don't name things you already love that

much — the name would have been extra, a receipt for something you already owned outright.

Also: a Catholic school where the nuns made you hold a bar of soap in your mouth for speaking your grandmother's language on school grounds unless your grandmother spoke English. This sounded like a punishment. It was, in the way things at that school always were, also a boast. The soap was French. It came from a shop in Makati that sold nothing else. Poor children got the belt for the same crime. Rich children were expensive to punish.

Also: Papa. The newspapers called him a statesman, and newspapers did not lie, exactly — they just left out the parts that wouldn't fit the column. They left out the belt. They left out the chair at the head of the dining table that the maids set every night for a man who came home maybe one night in five, so that eating dinner meant eating across from an empty plate that someone had gone to the trouble of filling with rice anyway, out of respect, or habit, or a refusal to admit the math. They left out that Papa insisted on Papa, never Dad, and that if you slipped, his face did something quick and total, like a door closing in another room — no slam, just a change in the air pressure of the house.

Jojo said Dad exactly once. He was five. He did not remember what came after, only that some muscle in him learned the lesson and never asked for a rematch. It would be the first of several muscles America eventually pointed out he no longer had.

Mahal sat in the window seat. She was ten, eleven months older — Irish twins, a phrase from the big Catholic families who had as many children as God and the rhythm method allowed, which described Mama's family exactly, ten or twelve of them, though Mama only ever mentioned the counting,

never the names. The window went to the oldest. The middle seat went to Jojo. The aisle belonged to a businessman who had fallen asleep with his mouth open and a glass of whiskey sweating on his tray table. It smelled like Papa's study, a room with a door Jojo had opened exactly twice and been told, both times, gently, to close.

The sushi came before the meal did. First class got it on real plates, with hot towels, in seats wide enough to hold two children and their opinions. Coach got a cart that rolled past like a parade you weren't invited to, and on it: nigiri, glistening, catching the cabin light.

The last time Jojo had seen his father was at a restaurant in Manila called Miyako. Papa had cleared the whole place for the night — paid off every table so it would just be them and six men in barong tagalog who called each other pare and laughed with their whole bodies. Jojo ate tempura shrimp drowned in a brown sauce that was not soy sauce, sweeter, thicker, a sauce he would spend the next forty years chasing on menus and never quite finding. Papa ate the nigiri with his fingers. Not chopsticks — fingers, the way you were supposed to eat it. When he chewed, his face went soft. It was the only time Jojo ever saw that particular softness, and he filed it away without knowing why, the way you keep a ticket stub from a movie you didn't understand yet.

He did not know it was the last time. Nobody hands you that information in advance. The sushi cart rolled past. He thought about Papa's fingers and the sauce and the men's laughter and Mahal, once, on Papa's lap during "Happy Birthday," off-key. Then the cart kept moving, because it had a schedule, and first class got their nigiri, and coach got the choice between two words.

"Chicken or beef?"

He pointed. The chicken arrived in foil, pale, faintly steaming, tasting of the container it came in. He thought about the yard in Manila — the chicken that had once been small enough to hold, that came running when he knelt and opened his hands. He thought about the evening he'd come home from school, eaten dinner, and gone looking for it afterward, and understood, slowly, the way you understand a word in a language you're only half fluent in, that he had already eaten it. He pushed the tray away. This chicken owed him nothing and he owed it nothing back, which was the whole problem — the airline chicken had never knelt for anyone.

The cabin lights dimmed. Mahal slept against the window, her breath fogging a small oval that kept vanishing and reappearing. He couldn't sleep. He hadn't seen Mama in four years, which at nine is not a number, it's a geological era — half a life spent being raised by a woman named Tita Julie, who was paid to look after them and did so with the attentiveness of a landlord inspecting a property she intended to flip.

Tita Julie had two faces, and switched between them the way a light switches on and off, with nothing in between. When Mama was in the house, or even just expected soon, Tita Julie smiled constantly, laughed a half-beat too loud at things that weren't funny, and found reasons to stand near Papa with her chin tilted up and her eyes doing something Jojo didn't have a word for yet but would later recognize, with some discomfort, as flirtation. The instant Mama's car pulled out of the driveway, or Papa's study door clicked shut, that whole face rearranged itself into something else entirely — flat, watchful, faintly reptilian, the exact expression Jojo would later recognize on a page of one of Mama's encyclopedias, in the entry for a Greek monster named Medusa, snakes for hair and a stare that turned people to stone. He spent hours with those

encyclopedias once he was old enough to reach the shelf — the same Grolier's and Britannica volumes Mama kept and displayed like trophies — pondering the pictures the same slow, hungry way Mama herself must once have pondered them, and every single time he reached the Medusa plate, he thought of Tita Julie's other face.

She told him things when nobody else was around to correct her. That he was adopted. That Mama hadn't really wanted him and had left for America the way you leave something you'd rather not keep carrying. That Papa loved Mahal — obviously, plainly, the way you love a child who actually looks like you — but had never quite managed the same thing for Jojo, and wasn't that just how it went sometimes, some children simply weren't as loved as others, it wasn't anybody's fault. He didn't believe her, not with the part of his brain that could argue back. But some smaller part of him, the part too young yet to argue, took notes anyway, and the notes had an ugly habit of matching the evidence every time Papa actually came home.

Because Papa did come home, in those years, for a few days at a stretch between one business trip and the next, and when he did, he picked Mahal up — actually lifted her, swung her, let her ride his shoulders out to the car — and told Jojo, not unkindly, just entirely without warmth, to go get his slippers. Even the names Papa used were evidence, if you were the kind of child who kept evidence, which Jojo eventually became. Josette he called Mahal, easily, warmly, the pet name arriving in his mouth like it cost him nothing. Jojo he called Joselito, always, the full formal weight of it, three syllables where one nickname would have done — correct, proper, and never once softened into anything smaller or closer.

Papa was never cruel to Jojo specifically. He was strict with

both of them evenly and generous with both of them evenly, the same toys, the same shoes, apparently without ever noticing he was doing anything different. But the noticing was never really the point. The affection simply wasn't there for Jojo the way it plainly was for Mahal, a fact so unremarked-upon that it took him years to even find language for it, and the closest thing to touch he ever reliably got from his father was the specific, functional contact of a spanking — sometimes for a reason he understood, sometimes for one he never did, and more than once, replaying it afterward the way a child replays everything looking for the shape of a rule, he was almost certain Tita Julie had gotten to the room first.

There had been rice on the floor — raw, uncooked, the grains still sharp enough to bite back — and his knees on the rice for as long as she decided the crime warranted, which was never a number he could predict in advance, because the crime itself was rarely something he could have named beforehand either. That was the part nobody who hadn't lived in that house would understand: it was never the same rule twice. A glass held wrong. A question asked in the wrong tone. Once, memorably, simply standing in a doorway she wanted to walk through. The rules did not preexist the punishment; they arrived at the same moment it did, freshly written, and he learned early that there was no version of good behavior reliable enough to protect him from it — which is its own particular kind of exhausting, keeping watch for a danger with no fixed shape. She liked to crouch to his eye level while he knelt there, close enough that he could smell her perfume under the smell of his own pain, and tell him — almost gently, the way you'd share a secret rather than issue a warning — that his lola, back in the province, used to press thumbtacks point-up into the floor for children who needed convincing twice, and that she still had some, somewhere, if the rice ever stopped being lesson

enough. He never once saw a thumbtack. He believed in them completely anyway, the way you believe anything said quietly and without anger, which turns out to be the most convincing register cruelty has. There had been chili pressed to his lips like a kiss from someone who'd mistaken punishment for affection. There had been the belt, once, and Tita Julie in the doorway, watching, her face doing something between concern and inventory.

That was over. That was the thing he was upgrading out of.

Mama's letters had described America the way missionaries describe heaven — with total conviction and zero firsthand evidence of anyone who'd actually seen it. Grocery stores the size of gymnasiums. Milk that came in gallons, a whole gallon, as if the cow had simply had an excellent week and nobody had thought to portion it out. A man named Uncle Rey, quiet and kind. And Big Macs — as big as his head, she'd promised, and he believed her, because his mother did not lie about hamburgers. She lied, if you could call it that, about gray skies and empty chairs and men with belts. Mama believed in three things, in this order depending on the week: Jesus, America, her children. She would hold all three until her last breath. Two of them would eventually let her down. She never told the third one that.

The captain's voice came over the intercom, flattened and polite. Descending into San Francisco. Overcast. Fifty-four degrees. Winds light, out of the west. Jojo did not know what overcast meant. It sounded like a spell — something cast over something else, a net thrown from a height you couldn't see. Mahal woke and found his hand without opening her eyes all the way, the way sisters do it, on instinct, like checking a stove is off.

The plane dropped into cloud. Gray swallowed the

window. His ears popped, then popped again, and then the gray broke apart and there it was: water the color of a nickel, sky the color of the water, a bridge the color of the sky, the whole city painted with the one crayon nobody ever wanted from the box.

He pressed his forehead to the glass, cold enough to sting, and thought: so this is the upgrade. He thought: Mama's letters had a lot of colors in them, and none of this was one of them.

Then he thought, "I should've ordered the beef."